

To Love or To Be Loved: That is the Question!

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Dharma Talks · 17:49

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Namō tassa bhagavato arahato sammā sambuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

So greetings to all you revelers in full moon delights. Some of these months lend themselves to certain subjects, so obviously this one is about love.

I reread Eric Fromm's classic, *The Art of Loving*. I've read it about five times over the years. Some of you might know it — definitely worth a read anyway. He starts off with something, but I'm going to turn it into a question: when we do something, or say something, or think something out of love, do we do it in order to love, in order to develop our love, or do we do it to be loved? That's a cheeky one, that, right?

He talks about why we need this love. Of course, it's a psychoanalysis thing. When we're born, for those first few months or so, there's no separation between us and our mothers. That's really a halcyon peace, a heavenly state to be in. Then, of course, the separation starts, which is needed for the child to become a little independent being. But that separation is a sense of loss. According to psychoanalysis, that's what produces our loneliness in life, because we want to get back to that wonderful place we were when we were babies.

From the Buddha's point of view, from the Dharma's point of view rather, of course, it's more to do with the essential relationship that we make with this psychophysical organism that we call the self. The self knows that it is unstable. It comes to know that it's not secure. So the fundamental position from a dharma point of view is this feeling of unsafety.

Because of that, we start collecting things. That's the first thing that the Buddha talks about. It's translated as greed, but it's much better to see it as acquisitiveness. So we acquire things, and there are four major areas where we do that, of course.

Rich — I want to be rich, loads of money, like Scrooge. The more I have, the safer I feel. If I've got a million pound in the bank, I feel really safe.

Then there's power. Control over our lives, control over people makes us feel safe. We're in charge. That can also be a real pain.

Then there's pleasure, of course — seeking people who just want one experience after the other. Been there, got the T-shirt, all that stuff. Foodies who live for the next exciting menu rather.

Finally, there's those who seek to be appreciated, seek to be praised. Usually we're seeking some sort of fame. Here we're dealing with fame or the desire to be loved.

That would be, of course, also a cause of loneliness. The fact that when we feel lonely, then we have these little words going on in our heads about how useless we are and horrible. What we do is reinforce that by forming friendships — padding out our friendships by making sure that they are stable friendships. We don't want to lose them because then we'd feel really lonely.

But that unfortunately is a bad strategy because what it does is make us dependent on them. What it means is that our self-worth or self-esteem is dependent on what other people think about us or what they say about us, how they treat us. Therefore, sometimes you feel pretty rotten if you do that.

Of course, people whom you love disappear. They either leave you or they get fed up with you, and some of them die. Nothing is to be taken for granted. So there's always that little sense of anxiety of loss. Anything you become attached to is going to create some anxiety of loss.

The other thing we do, of course, is to seek distraction. I'll come to that in a minute.

So the best strategy is actually to love, right, to come from the position of love. When you come from a position of love, you immediately fill yourself with good feelings, good feelings about yourself. That sense of self-worth, self-esteem comes naturally when we behave from a position of love and all the other social virtues of compassion, joy, etc.

So how do we purify our love? First of all, it's to recognize that this thing about the self and its feeling lonely and its neediness — that has to be recognized so that when we are doing something, we've got to see these little background voices. In the Buddhist teachings, they're known as latent tendencies, the *anusaya*, the latent tendencies. So they're always there, ready to be fired. In psychology, they'd call it subconscious motivations. That's where we get the idea of Freudian slips. Something's happening in the back of the mind, we're not recognizing it, and it comes out in a slip that makes us feel embarrassed.

When we're about to do something or say something or even think something, you've always got to be aware of this little other dialogue that's going on. So it might be, for instance, "Well, I'm going to do your garden," and the background little voice is saying, "And you'll come and do mine when I need it," or "I know you'll really love me after this. You'll really appreciate my friendship." So there's always these little things going on in the background. It's a case really of making those conscious.

Now, as soon as they become conscious, they lose power over you. If you remember, after the Buddha was fully liberated, there were seven years it said that Mara chased him with his three daughters. Sensual desire, sexual desire... and if you don't know the third one, I'll leave you to guess it. After seven years, he began to go away. He said, "What's happening?" He said, "Well, the Buddha sees me. He sees me." He said, "Well, give us a bit more time." He said, "No," he says, "after seven years, I'm not going to get through to the Buddha."

So as soon as we see these little conversations coming from the self, the neediness of the self, the wanting to be loved, they don't have power over us. We then reestablish our commitment to doing something from the heart of love. That's how we begin to purify our hearts.

Now, the purification of the heart demands a lessening of the self. So therefore, the path of love is a path of liberation. The path of purification is itself a path of liberation. Normally, of course, we put the accent on insight, on seeing things, which is absolutely necessary as well. But with the path of love, this is the process. You're constantly purifying your intentions, coming from the heart.

It's funny, there's always an effort in philosophy to give you reasons. There's not time to go into the way that philosophers think about ethical behaviour, love, compassion and joy and all that. They try to give us rational reasons. But the great Scottish philosopher, Hume — I've heard him called the philosopher's philosopher — says that whenever he looked into an act of goodwill, he didn't find a reason at the bottom of it, but he found a sentiment. That's his word for something that arises out of the heart. Confucius said that the ground of a harmonious society was benevolence and concern, love and compassion.

Everything around love always begins in the heart. Now, the only problem is that it's not always a feeling. You don't have to feel loving in order to act from a position of goodwill. For instance, a surgeon who's operating — I doubt if they feel some great big gushing love towards their patient. I mean, their attention is on what they're doing. They should be equanimous, calm, cool.

So again, when we say the heart, we're really talking about attitude. We're not talking about feeling. The feeling is sometimes there and sometimes it isn't. That's important.

That gives us some idea as to how to make our acts of love, the way we speak and the way we think, coming from the heart of love, more and more pure. But let's just say a word about loneliness.

When we feel lonely, it's a bit of a downer for the self because the language is something like, "Nobody loves me. Who could love me? I mean, I'm horrible." All that really, really upsetting talk. So we try to escape that. As soon as you feel lonely, as soon as it actually just drips into consciousness, off we go. We turn on the TV, get onto social media, open a new packet of biscuits — anything but feel the loneliness.

That's, of course, why we don't like to tell people we feel lonely, because what we're saying to them is that we're not loved. We're not appreciated. So it's a difficult one for us.

Now, by trying to escape it, of course, it still remains there as one of these *anusaya*, as one of these latent tendencies. What it's going to do is make you overact your love to other people so that you can prove that you are appreciated. You're going to be overly joyous at people's success just so they know that you are joyous and that you are to be praised because of that and appreciated and loved.

So you've got to tackle the loneliness in its rawness. This is what Vipassanā teaches us. We go into the mental state, the feel of it. You have to have the patience. You have to be open to it. It helps to have a sense

of care towards it, a sense of wanting to heal the heart of it. That gives you a right attitude towards the feeling of loneliness.

But you still have to go in there. You have to sink into it and feel the raw feelings. Of course, what you're doing is you're opening up to your heart. The heart wants to speak to you. It speaks in feelings, in mental states. In so doing, we're letting off that steam. We're allowing that turbulence to manifest as turbulence, as energy. Therefore, it's exhausting itself, just like anything else. If you go for a run, at the end of it, you feel exhausted. So if you give the heart a run, it'll feel exhausted.

Now the really important thing is, if you can — this is a really important thing — if you can stay to the very last sensation caused by that loneliness, because if you stay there, you might see the transformation. That energy is never lost. It always transforms towards its opposite. What you may experience is a sense of wonderful relief and peacefulness. But also, to your great surprise, it might burst out into this universal love for all beings. It's quite remarkable what will happen if you stay to the end.

You don't have to stay to the end for this technique to allow the heart to purify itself. But if you do, it gives you real confidence because now you know that all these negative mental states are always moving towards the opposites. No energy is lost. Of course, that doesn't mean to say that when they are their opposites, when you do feel love, these mental states can be developed indefinitely. In other words, after this year of real commitment, you should be constantly sailing in a sea of joyous love. No doubt about it.

Unfortunately, this universal love that we're trying to get to, this love which is above any love to do with attachments, is something we have to develop. All these other loves, if you think about it, come naturally. I mean, there's a natural loving of parents towards their children. You don't organize yourself. You don't set yourself up to fall in love. You just fall in love. You meet somebody and you like them, and before you know it, you fall in love, or you've developed a friendship because of that connection between two hearts. All these types of love are just part of our natural human nature, but to lift it into this universal love, this *mettā*, takes effort. You've got to lift yourself out of that stuff and really make an effort to open up your heart to all beings in all directions. So that's really the final thing.

So the question then is, to love or to be loved, right? Like Shakespeare in Hamlet: "That is the question." To love or to be loved in terms of our daily activity, in terms of our spiritual practice. If we keep an eye on these *anusaya*, these latent tendencies, we'll get a hang of it.

It means that you've got to have a slightly more spacious awareness, an awareness which is not only about what's out there, but a constant inner awareness. You know all the time how you're feeling. It's just there in the background. When something moves, an irritation or something like that, you become aware of it. Because you're aware of it, it no longer has control over you. You can just either park it — so you're not pushing it away with fear or with aversion. Those are suppressive measures. You're just putting it to the side and reestablishing your attitude, your act of will.

I think that's it. I think I've done it. So I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that by your sincere practice of goodwill and concern, you will be liberated from all sufferings sooner rather than later.

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